# Saryarqa Go: book Kazakhstan with confidence

An English / Chinese booking app that helps Saryarqa Routes reach 30% foreign travelers within 24 months.
Team: _____

## 1. Summary

Saryarqa Routes sells guided trips almost only to Kazakhstan residents because its sales process (Instagram messages, WhatsApp, phone, Kaspi or cash, a Russian-only one-page site) does not work for foreigners Case fact. Saryarqa Go is a bilingual booking app built as one closed loop (Discover, Plan, Verify, Book, Travel, Share) that answers the four complaints foreign guests actually made. We start with Chinese-speaking independent travelers. The 12-week MVP fits the 20,000,000 KZT year-1 budget and, under stated assumptions, pays back in month 32 (base) or month 44 (downside).

## 2. Problem and relevance

Saryarqa Routes (Astana, founded 2020; 9 staff, ~25 freelance guides) served 3,400 travelers in 2025 with revenue of 150,000,000 KZT and an average price of 44,000 KZT; about 96% were from Kazakhstan. The goal is 30% foreign travelers within 24 months Case fact. Foreign guests named four problems, and each one stops a sale before payment:

| Guest said Case fact | Where the sale breaks | Root cause today |
|---|---|---|
| "It is unclear how to book." | Before first contact | Chat-only sales; Russian-only one-page website |
| "I am not sure the company is trustworthy." | Before paying abroad | No visible proof; no way to meet the people |
| "My foreign card does not work." | At payment | Kaspi transfer or cash only |
| "I do not know what is included." | Before committing | No structured description of the price |

### Why Chinese-speaking independent travelers first

- **Fast-growing market.** Kazakhstan received about 655,000 visitors from China in 2024, +78% vs 367,000 in 2023, according to the Ministry of Tourism and Sports [1][2] Verified source. China was the largest source market outside the near abroad in 2024 [3] Verified source.
- **No visa barrier.** A mutual visa-free regime has applied since November 2023: up to 30 days per visit, max 90 days in 180 [1] Verified source. The decision is about trust, clarity and payment, exactly the four complaints.
- **Big inbound flow overall.** Kazakhstan counted 15.3 million foreign visitors for tourism purposes in 2024 [3] and 15.7 million in the first nine months of 2025 [5] Verified source.
- **Product fit.** Nature and photography (Charyn, Kolsai, Burabay) and Silk Road culture (Turkestan) match what independent travelers look for Proposal.

Method note: an analyst estimate of 241,700 Chinese visitors in 2025 [4] uses a different method from the Ministry figure for 2024 [1], so the two are not compared. National visitor counts [3][5] and World Bank / UN Tourism overnight arrivals [6] use different definitions.

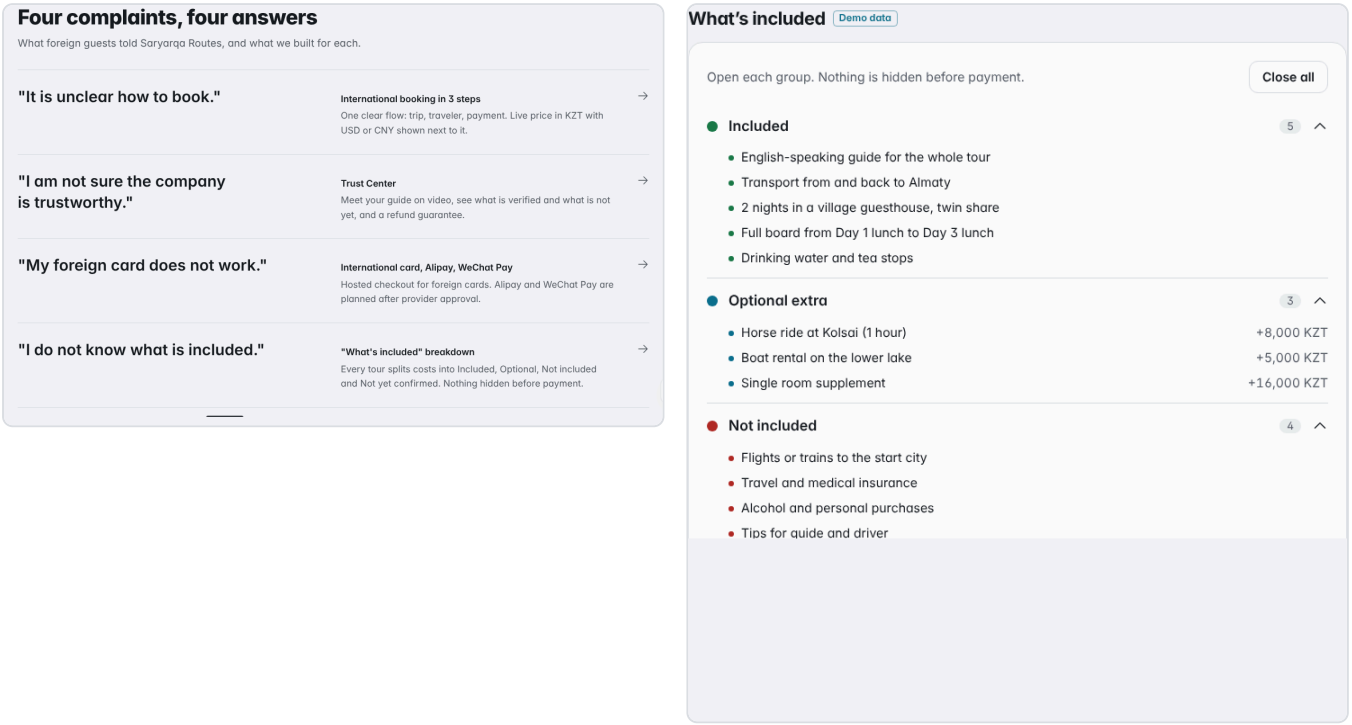
### The size of the job

About 4% of 3,400 ≈ 136 travelers are foreign today. Keeping ≈ 3,264 domestic travelers, 30% foreign needs ≈ 4,663 travelers in total, so ≈ 1,399 foreign: about **1,263 more foreign travelers per year**, ≈ 105 per month. One complaint fixed at a time will not get there; the whole buying journey must work for a foreigner.

## 3. The product: Saryarqa Go

One closed loop instead of a pile of features. Every step removes one doubt, and the last step brings the next traveler back to the first.

| Step | What the traveler gets | Complaint answered |
|---|---|---|
| **Discover** | Tour pages in EN / 中文; "What's included" in four groups: Included, Optional extra, Not included, Not yet confirmed | "I do not know what is included" |
| **Plan** | Trip builder: arrival, real tour days, Almaty / Turkestan / Astana transfers, city days, cost estimate | "It is unclear how to book" |
| **Verify** | Trust Center: guide intro video, 5-minute video call before paying, honest verification checklist, refund rules; bilingual concierge that hands off to a human when unsure | "I am not sure the company is trustworthy" |
| **Book** | Three steps (trip, lead traveler, payment); international card via the provider's hosted checkout; Alipay / WeChat Pay after provider approval; price in KZT with USD / CNY | "My foreign card does not work"; "unclear how to book" |
| **Travel** | Timeline with daily check-ins, opt-in family updates (no GPS), weather and road-closure rescheduling, audio guide in Chinese | Trust during the trip |
| **Share** | Postcard sized for Xiaohongshu / WeChat Moments with a referral link that opens step 1 for a friend | Low-cost acquisition |




Prototype screens: the four complaints mapped to features (left) and the four-group "What's included" breakdown (right). Full flow and more screens in the separate flow document.

## 4. Originality and unique value

- **"Not yet confirmed" as a feature.** Park fees, guesthouse names, the Kaindy 4×4 transfer and Chinese-guide availability are shown openly and confirmed in writing before the trip. Honesty about the unknown is the trust signal.

- **Meet the guide before you pay.** For a traveler abroad, the guide is the company. A short video and an optional 5-minute call turn an unknown firm into a person.
- **A concierge that refuses to guess.** It answers in the traveler's language from verified tour data only and passes availability, discount and edge-case questions to a manager.
- **Safety for the family at home.** Opt-in, one trip only, ends automatically, shares check-in status rather than live location.
- **The postcard closes the loop.** Content the traveler wants to post anyway becomes the cheapest acquisition channel.
- **Honesty labels everywhere.** Every claim in the app is marked Case fact, Verified source, Proposal, Demo data or Needs confirmation.

## 5. Feasibility: a realistic 12-week MVP

| Weeks | Work | Done when |
|---|---|---|
| W1-2 | Research and validation; apply to payment providers | 10+ traveler interviews done; applications sent |
| W3-4 | UX and EN / 中文 tour pages | 4 tour pages reviewed by 3+ target users |
| W5-7 | Booking, inclusions, concierge, Trust Center | End-to-end test booking in payment sandbox |
| W8-9 | Trip builder, live checkout, reschedule workflow | First real test payment by staff |
| W10-11 | Usability tests; payment-provider checks | 5-8 sessions, no blocking issue left |
| W12 | Pilot with real travelers | Pilot metrics collected |

**Rule:** anything that needs a third party's approval or live data waits for later (live LLM concierge, Alipay / WeChat Pay, live weather, GPS sharing, offline audio, Trip.com / Klook). The MVP therefore ships in 12 weeks regardless. **Tools:** React + TypeScript web app (reuses the prototype), managed database with admin panel, payment provider hosted checkout with webhooks. **People:** a contracted designer, two developers and a Chinese localizer, with one Saryarqa Routes staff member as product owner Proposal.

**Proof:** a working clickable prototype already covers the whole loop (booking with validation and a simulated declined payment, bilingual concierge, trip builder, trust center, in-trip screen, postcard, live payback calculator). An automated test checks 75 acceptance points, including phone width and dark mode; all pass. Payments are simulated in the prototype (TEST MODE); no card or passport data is collected.

## 6. Costs, payback and impact

| **20.0M KZT** | **13,200 KZT** | **Month 32** | **Month 44** |
|---|---|---|---|
| year-1 budget (12.0M one-time) | contribution per traveler | payback, base case | payback, downside (× 0.7) |

Revenue comes from the margin on additional foreign travelers (44,000 KZT × 30% assumed margin) Proposal. Break-even needs 1,516 extra foreign travelers in total. Payback falls inside 48 months for any margin of 20% or more in the base case; the downside needs about 30% or more. Full budget, revenue model, yearly cash flow and sensitivity are in the separate financial document.

**Impact** Proposal: a second, foreign revenue stream for the company beside its domestic base; travelers get clear prices, their own payment method and a guide they have met; Kazakhstan gets an easy-to-book, trustworthy experience that Chinese travelers share on their own social platforms, spreading demand to regions beyond the big cities.

## 7. Risks and how we reduce them

| Risk | Mitigation |
|---|---|
| Alipay / WeChat Pay approval slow or refused | Launch with international cards via hosted checkout; apply in week 1; manager-assisted payment as fallback |
| Concierge gives a wrong answer | Verified data only, visible labels, "I won't guess" rule with human hand-off, weekly log review |
| Low demand from Chinese travelers | Interviews before building; small pilot; test Xiaohongshu content and postcards before paid ads |
| Cross-border data and privacy | Minimum data (no passport, no card numbers); legal review; family sharing off by default |
| Guides' Chinese is not good enough | Language test; interpreter partners; "Not yet confirmed" until checked; Chinese audio guide as backup |

Still to verify before launch **Needs confirmation**: business registration, operator licence and insurance documents; park and site fees; payment-provider terms; the 30% margin against real costs.